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**LOWER EAST SIDE  
CULTURAL CENTER**

# ALLEN MALL

**FROM VACANT TO VITAL:  
A COMMUNITY-LED CULTURAL CENTER  
FOR THE LOWER EAST SIDE**

**2026**



**DELANCEY STREET  
COMFORT STATION**

**ADAPTIVE REUSE-  
COMMUNITY CULTURAL CENTER**



Conceptual rendering.



# LOWER EAST SIDE CULTURAL CENTER

## MISSION

Our mission is to preserve the Lower East Side's cultural heritage while providing accessible, year-round programming that supports local artists, families, youth and community elders.

# LOWER EAST SIDE CULTURAL CENTER

**A DECOMMISSIONED NYC PARKS FACILITY  
PRESENTS AN OPPORTUNITY FOR YEAR-ROUND,  
PUBLICLY ACCESSIBLE, COMMUNITY-SERVING USE**

## VISION

A proposed Lower East Side Cultural Center (LESCC) will transform a currently underutilized Parks Department facility into a vibrant, community-centered hub for **arts, culture, education and inter-generational connection.**

This project responds to long-standing community interest in the site & aligns with the City's goals around cultural equity, youth engagement, accessible restrooms and the activation of public assets.

Proposing a multidisciplinary cultural hub; offering arts education, community storytelling, small performances, heritage programming & low-cost creative workspace as a way to **hold onto neighborhood history & lived experience as the Lower East Side continues to change.**

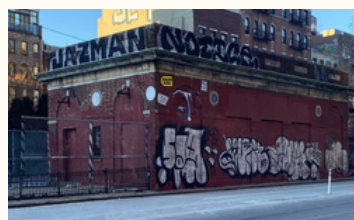


Conceptual rendering.

| OFFERING                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | OUTCOMES                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Multi-generational learning. Youth and inter-generational engagement.</li> <li>Weekly workshops &amp; monthly community events/celebrations of diverse cultural traditions.</li> <li>Youth-centered after-school programming.</li> <li>Activation of an underutilized Parks asset through consistent, stewarded public use.</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Free and low-cost programs delivered year-round.</li> <li>Community partnerships with local schools, cultural orgs, and service providers.</li> <li>Job creation and paid opportunities for local artists and educators.</li> <li>Increased park activation and public safety through regular use.</li> <li>Preservation of Lower East Side cultural history.</li> </ul> |

**Built with the neighborhood, for the neighborhood—** placing local voices at the center of decision-making & impact. The project is backed by experienced cultural organizers and community partners with a demonstrated capacity to steward public space responsibly.

**Prepared in advance of an anticipated NYC Parks RFP. Early conversations welcomed.**



## CONNECT:

**MYLES SMUTNEY - FOUNDER**  
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THEFREESTOREPROJECT@GMAIL.COM







## LOWER EAST SIDE

# CULTURAL CENTER

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The proposed Lower East Side Cultural Center (LESCC) will transform a currently underutilized Parks Department facility into a vibrant, community-centered hub for arts, culture, education, and intergenerational connection.

Our mission is to **preserve the neighborhood's cultural heritage while providing accessible, year-round programming that supports local artists, families, youth, and elders.**

LESCC will serve as a welcoming public anchor where residents can gather, create, learn, and celebrate the diverse cultural traditions that define the Lower East Side.

# COMMUNITY BENEFITS

**The Lower East Side Cultural Center will revitalize a dormant public building into an accessible, dynamic, community-driven cultural asset. This project honors the neighborhood's heritage, supports local artists, and expands cultural access for all residents — fulfilling the Parks Department's mission of activating public spaces with meaningful, equitable community benefit.**

LESCC's mission is to preserve and celebrate the cultural heritage of the Lower East Side while fostering accessible pathways to creative expression, education, and community connection.

The Center will operate with a deep commitment to inclusion, affordability, and local collaboration.

## **LESCC WILL GENERATE SUBSTANTIAL PUBLIC BENEFIT THROUGH:**

- ACCESSIBLE YEAR-ROUND CULTURAL PROGRAMMING
- LOCAL JOB CREATION AND ARTIST OPPORTUNITIES
- STRENGTHENED RELATIONSHIPS WITH NEIGHBORHOOD SCHOOLS AND COMMUNITY GROUPS
- INCREASED SAFETY AND ACTIVITY AROUND THE FACILITY
- PRESERVATION AND CELEBRATION OF LES CULTURAL HISTORY
- FREE AND INCLUSIVE GATHERING SPACE FOR UNDERSERVED RESIDENTS

### **Organizational Capacity**

LESCC will be managed by a team with experience in arts education, cultural programming, nonprofit administration, and community development. A Community Advisory Council will guide program direction and ensure local representation.

### **LESCC team will:**

- PRIORITIZE PROGRAMMING LED BY LOCAL BIPOC, IMMIGRANT, AND LGBTQ+ ARTISTS
- ENSURE MULTILINGUAL SIGNAGE AND OUTREACH
- GUARANTEE ADA PHYSICAL ACCESS AND SENSORY-FRIENDLY PROGRAM OPTIONS
- OFFER GENEROUS FEE WAIVERS AND SCHOLARSHIPS
- CO-DESIGN PROGRAMS WITH COMMUNITY PARTNERS

**This Center will be not just a building, but a living cultural ecosystem grounded in justice, belonging, and public access.**



# COMMUNITY



## COMMUNITY NEED & ALIGNMENT WITH NYC PARKS GOALS

The Lower East Side has long been a home to immigrant communities, creatives, and grassroots cultural movements. Yet many small arts organizations and independent artists face barriers to space, stability, and resources.

### Residents consistently cite a need for:

- AFFORDABLE CULTURAL PROGRAMMING
- INTERGENERATIONAL GATHERING SPACES
- FREE OR LOW-COST ARTS EDUCATION
- SAFE AFTER-SCHOOL YOUTH PROGRAMS
- ACCESSIBLE VENUES FOR CULTURAL GROUPS AND NEIGHBORHOOD TRADITIONS

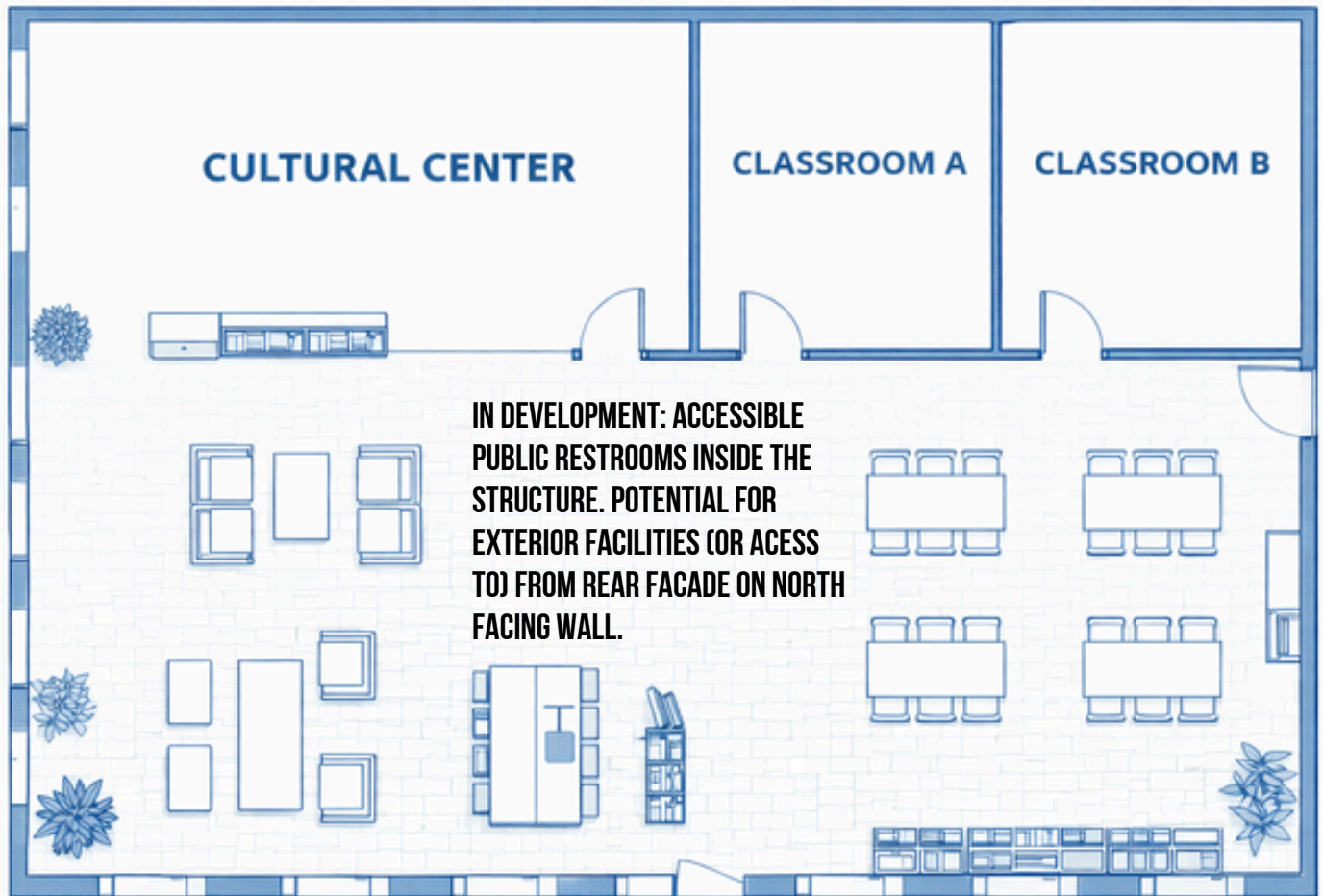
This project directly aligns with NYC Parks' goals of **revitalizing public assets, supporting community-serving uses, encouraging local engagement, and ensuring equitable access to cultural resources.**

By activating a decommissioned Parks building with high-impact public benefit, LESCC contributes to neighborhood vitality, safety, and shared stewardship of the site.

As the neighborhood changes, rich stories, history & tradition can be shared with new generations.









# PROPOSED FACILITY USE

The building will be renovated into accessible creative spaces for workshops, visual arts, textiles, and performance, using storytelling to carry forward cultural knowledge and lived experience within a rapidly changing Lower East Side.

THE LOWER EAST SIDE CULTURAL CENTER WILL BE PROGRAMMED AS A MULTI-USE CULTURAL FACILITY FEATURING:

## ■ COMMUNITY RESOURCE OFFICE

A STAFFED SPACE PROVIDING PARTNERSHIPS, VOLUNTEER COORDINATION, AND LOCAL OUTREACH. WORKING IN CONCERT WITH OTHER AREA ORGANIZATIONS TO OFFER HOUSING, LEGAL AID AND OTHER SOCIAL SERVICES.

## ■ EXHIBITION & EVENT HALL

A FLEXIBLE ROOM FOR SMALL PERFORMANCES, ROTATING EXHIBITIONS, FILM NIGHTS, COMMUNITY MEETINGS, AND NEIGHBORHOOD CELEBRATIONS.

## ■ YOUTH (& FAMILY) LEARNING LAB

AFTER-SCHOOL ARTS PROGRAMS, TEEN CREATIVE LEADERSHIP INITIATIVES, WEEKEND WORKSHOPS, AND FAMILY-CENTERED ACTIVITIES.

## ■ CULTURAL HERITAGE ARCHIVE ROOM

A SMALL GALLERY AND DIGITAL ARCHIVE PRESERVING LES IMMIGRANT HISTORIES, ORAL TRADITIONS, AND NEIGHBORHOOD CULTURAL MEMORY.

## ■ COMMUNITY ARTS STUDIOS

LOW-COST SPACES FOR WORKSHOPS IN VISUAL ARTS, TEXTILES, PERFORMANCE, AND STORYTELLING.



# PROPOSED FACILITY USE

THIS IS A PRELIMINARY CONCEPTUALIZATION OF THE LOWER EAST SIDE CULTURAL CENTER -  
PENDING ARCHITECTURAL REVIEW.

## FIRST FLOOR (OPEN TO THE PUBLIC):

### ■ ENTRY / WELCOME AREA (FRONT FACING) ENTRY GLASS DOORS - DELANCEY STREET

- SECURITY GUARD
- SMALL SEATING AREA
- DISPLAY CASE/ BOOKSHELF/ INFO ABOUT PROGRAMMING
- COFFEE CONCESSION
- PUBLICLY ACCESSIBLE RESTROOM (ADA COMPLIANT)
- VISIBILITY INTO MAIN HALL
- NEIGHBORHOOD VISIBILITY - LARGE WINDOWS

### ■ FLEXIBLE EXHIBITION + EVENT HALL (CORE SPACE)

- |                              |       |                      |
|------------------------------|-------|----------------------|
| • MAIN OPEN ROOM             | USES: | • EXHIBITIONS        |
| • MOVABLE WALLS / PARTITIONS |       | • PERFORMANCES       |
| • CAPACITY: ~40-75 PEOPLE    |       | • FILM NIGHTS        |
|                              |       | • COMMUNITY MEETINGS |

### ■ COMMUNITY PROGRAMMING (ARTS & EDUCATION) TWO SMALL ROOMS

- |       |                  |                   |                                  |
|-------|------------------|-------------------|----------------------------------|
| USES: | • WORKSHOPS      | • REHEARSAL SPACE | • TEXTILES /PRINTMAKING          |
|       | • YOUTH PROGRAMS | • CLASSROOMS      | • PARTNER ORG EVENTS/PROGRAMMING |

## BASMENT (SEMI-PRIVATE):

### ■ COMMUNITY RESOURCE OFFICE/CULTURAL HERITAGE ARCHIVE ROOM

- |       |                            |                                    |            |
|-------|----------------------------|------------------------------------|------------|
| USES: | • PARTNER ORG OFFICE HOURS | • ADMIN BASE                       | • ARCHIVES |
|       | • CASE WORKERS/OUTREACH    | • ORAL HISTORIES/LISTENING STATION |            |

### ■ COMMUNITY ART STUDIOS (TWO)

TWO LOW-COST SPACES FOR WORKSHOPS IN VISUAL ARTS, TEXTILES, PERFORMANCE, AND STORYTELLING.

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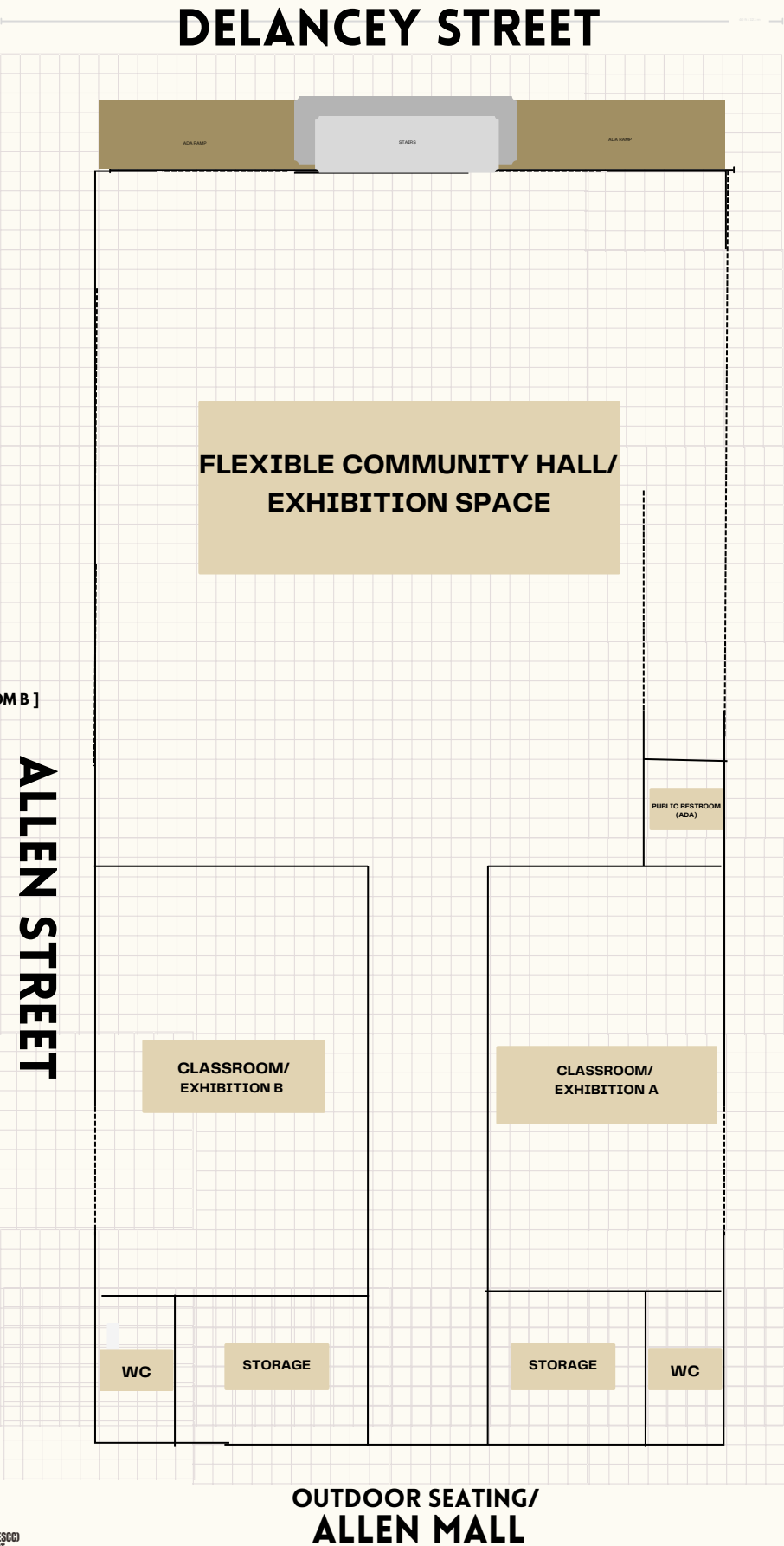
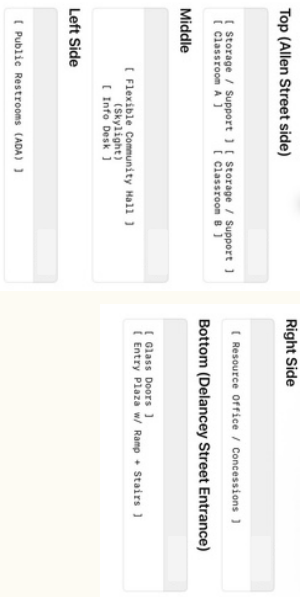
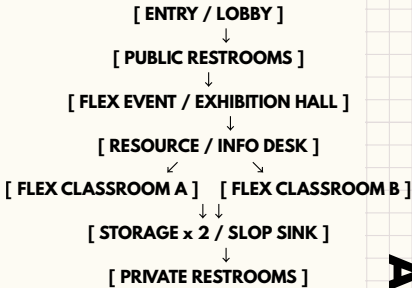
PROJECT OVERVIEW:

CONCEPTUAL LAYOUT FOR  
PROGRAM & SPATIAL PLANNING -  
SUBJECT TO  
ARCHITECTURAL DEVELOPMENT.

Key:

- Solid lines for permanent walls
- Dashed lines for windows and movable walls
- Arrowed lines for pathways

CENTRAL CIRCULATION SPINE  
CONNECTS ALL PROGRAM AREAS



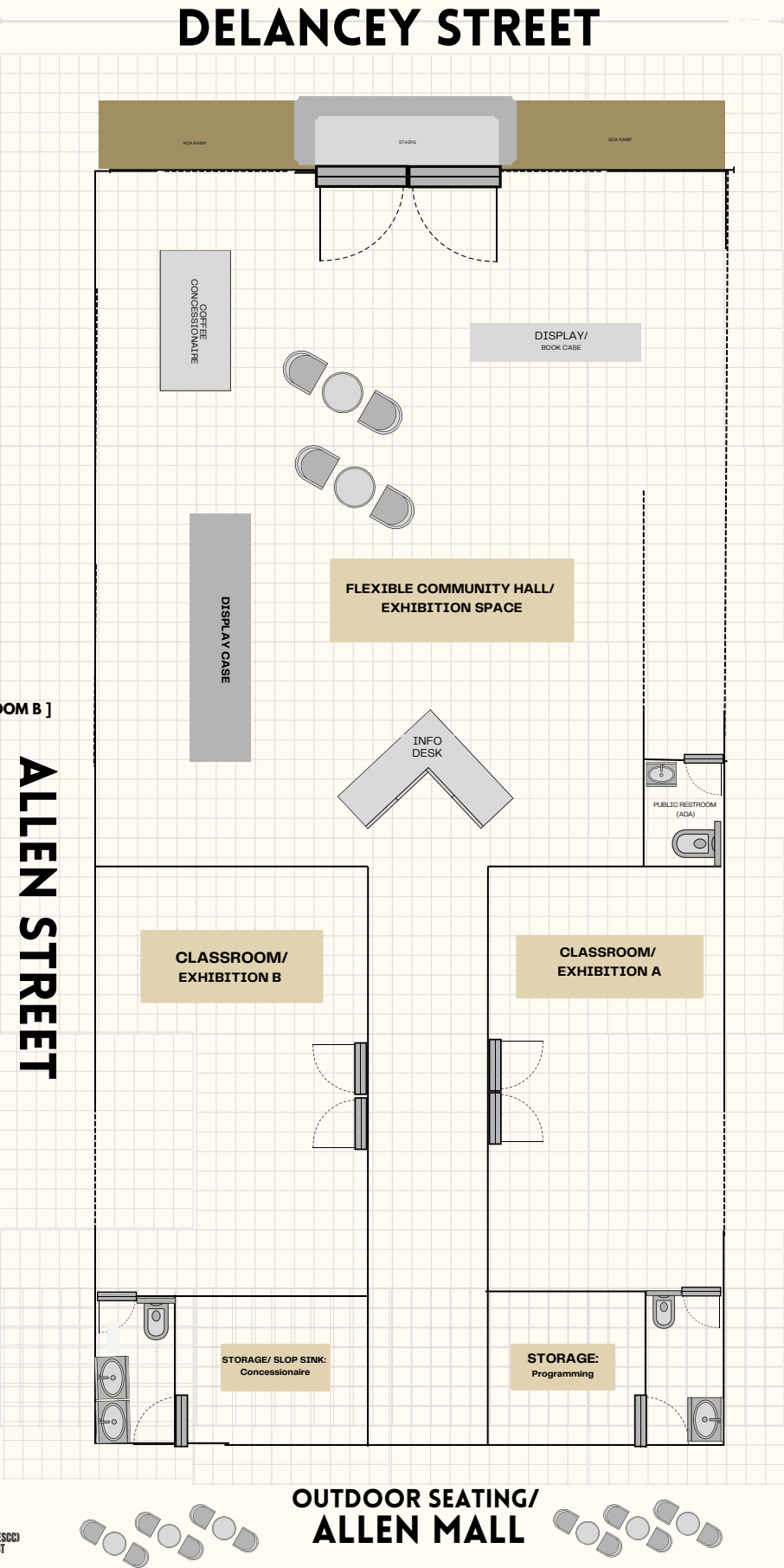
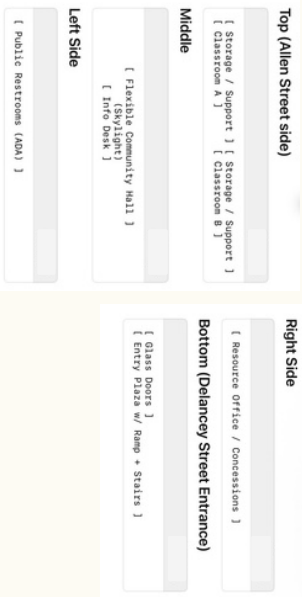
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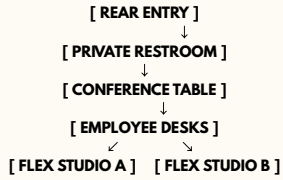
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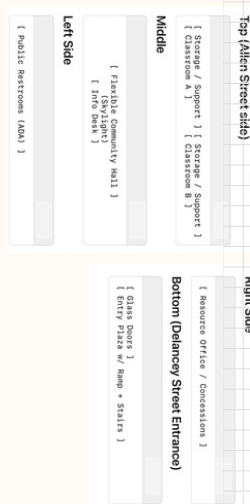
CONCEPTUAL SITE PLAN  
PROJECT OVERVIEW:



Toolkit

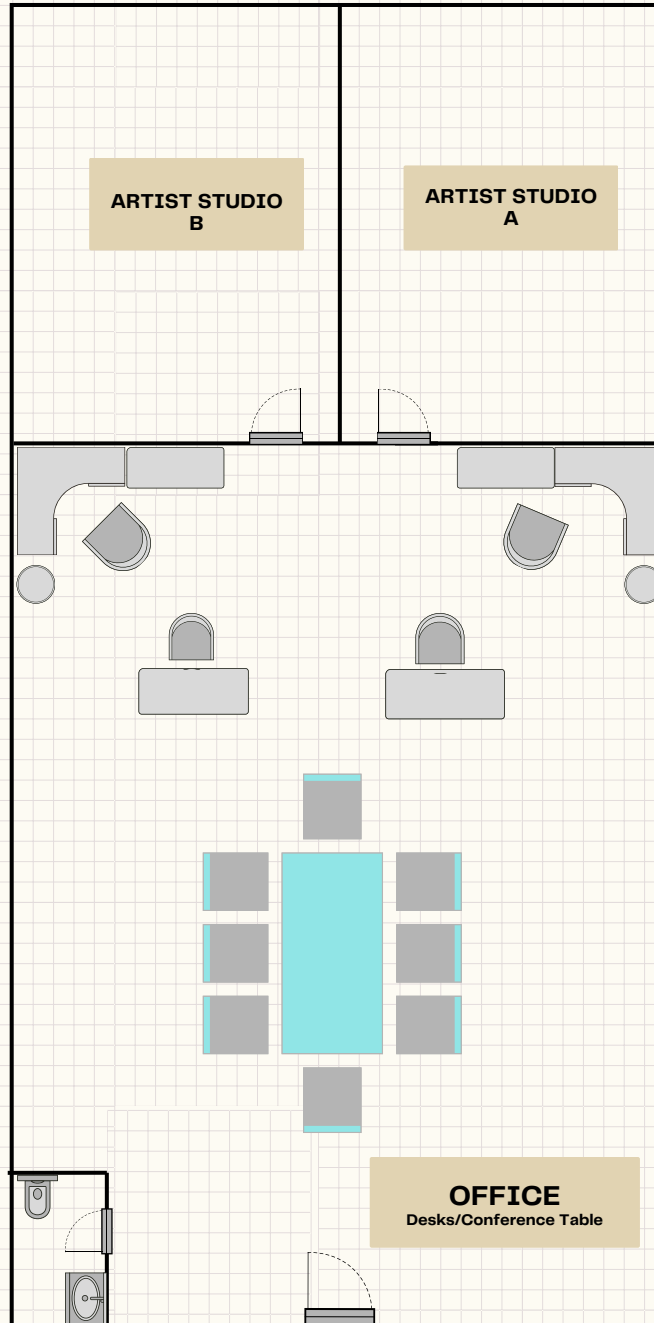
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CONCEPTUAL LAYOUT FOR  
PROGRAM & SPATIAL PLANNING -  
SUBJECT TO  
ARCHITECTURAL DEVELOPMENT.



ALLEN STREET

DELANCEY STREET



ALLEN STREET

OUTDOOR SEATING/  
ALLEN MALL

# INCLUSIVE PROGRAMMING

## ACCESSIBILITY/AFFORDABILITY

### MULTILINGUAL CLASSES AND EVENTS

- TEEN CREATIVE FELLOWSHIPS AND MENTORSHIP
- COLLABORATIVE PROJECTS WITH LOCAL SCHOOLS AND SENIOR CENTERS
- CULTURAL HERITAGE PRESERVATION PROJECTS
- INTERGENERATIONAL PROGRAMMING
- AFFORDABLE REHEARSAL AND MEETING SPACE RENTALS
- FREE/LOW-COST ARTS WORKSHOPS AND CLASSES

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**At least 40% of programming will be free and the remainder will be offered at low cost with sliding scale options.**

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All events will integrate accessibility measures, including ASL interpretation for select programs, multilingual materials, and ADA-compliant layouts.







# PROGRAMMING PRINCIPLES

PROGRAMS ARE DIVIDED INTO: CORE WEEKLY OFFERINGS, MONTHLY SIGNATURE PROGRAMS AND SEASONAL FESTIVALS. ROTATING EXHIBITIONS AND ACTIVE USE OF THE STUDIO SPACE OFFER OPPORTUNITIES FOR PROGRAMS TO REFLECT CURRENT WORLD EVENTS.



**All programming at LESCC is designed to be:**

- COMMUNITY-DRIVEN AND RESPONSIVE TO NEIGHBORHOOD NEEDS
- AFFORDABLE AND ACCESSIBLE (MINIMUM 40% FREE)
- INTERGENERATIONAL AND MULTILINGUAL
- ARTIST-LED, PRIORITIZING LOCAL CREATORS
- SCALABLE, ALLOWING GROWTH OVER TIME





# PROGRAM KEYS

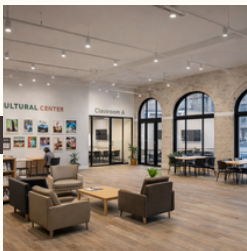
The Center is assumed to operate as a nonprofit organization or fiscally sponsored project in its first years.

ALL PROGRAMMING AT LESCC IS DESIGNED TO BE SCALABLE, ALLOWING GROWTH OVER TIME. THIS SCALABLE MODEL PRIORITIZES LONG-TERM SUSTAINABILITY, PUBLIC ACCESS, AFFORDABILITY, FAIR COMPENSATION FOR ARTISTS/STAFF AND GRADUAL EXPANSION AS FUNDING STABILIZES.



## REFLECTIVE OF THE COMMUNITY

- COMMUNITY-DRIVEN AND RESPONSIVE TO NEIGHBORHOOD NEEDS
- SEASONAL CULTURAL FESTIVALS CELEBRATING NEIGHBORHOOD HERITAGE



## REFLECTIVE OF THE CURRENT TIMES

- ARTIST-LED, PRIORITIZING LOCAL CREATORS
- PUBLIC EXHIBITIONS OF LOCAL ARTISTS AND YOUTH WORK



## OPEN ENROLLMENT

- FREE/LOW-COST ARTS WORKSHOPS AND CLASSES
- LOCAL ARTIST EXHIBITIONS + SMALL PERFORMANCES

# WEEKLY

## CORE PROGRAMS (YEAR-ROUND)

### COMMUNITY ARTS WORKSHOPS

- Visual arts (drawing, painting, collage)
- Textiles & fiber arts
- Printmaking & zines
- Creative writing & storytelling

Audience: Adults, seniors, intergenerational  
Cost: Free–\$10 sliding scale

### AFTER SCHOOL YOUTH CREATIVE LAB

- Art-making & design
- Media literacy & creative tech
- Mentorship with local artists
- Culminating youth showcases

Audience: Ages 10–17  
Cost: Free

### OPEN STUDIO HOURS

- Affordable workspace for artists
- Drop-in creative time
- Material-sharing library in partnership with Materials for the Arts

Drop-in workshops for caregivers + kids  
Multilingual facilitation

### HEALTH AND WELLNESS

- Community Yoga + Dance classes
- Somatic movement
- Senior-friendly mobility classes

Audience: Adults & seniors  
Cost: Free–\$10

### CULTURAL HERITAGE ARCHIVE HOURS

- Oral history recordings
- Photo scanning days
- Community storytelling sessions

Audience: All ages  
Cost: Free

# MONTHLY

## SIGNATURE PROGRAMMING

**A**

### FIRST FRIDAYS: LES OPEN HOUSE (MONTHLY)

Free exhibitions  
Open studios  
Performances  
Community potluck or gathering

**B**

### NEIGHBORHOOD VOICES SERIES (MONTHLY)

Artist talks  
Author readings  
Activist & elder storytelling  
Panel discussions

**C**

### FAMILY ART SATURDAYS (MONTHLY)

Drop-in workshops for caregivers + kids  
Multilingual facilitation

**D**

### PERSONAL • COMMUNITY FILM NIGHTS (MONTHLY)

Documentary screenings  
Local filmmaker showcases  
Post-film discussions

### HERITAGE • COMMUNITY FOCUS/HIGHLIGHTS (MONTHLY)

Martin Luther King Jr. Day, Independence Day, Cinco De Mayo  
Jewish & Yiddish Cultural Holidays Historically central to the Lower East Side, Latinx, Caribbean & Afro-Diasporic Holidays, Three Kings Day (Día de los Reyes), Afro-Latinx Heritage Month (October), Carnaval, Día de los Muertos, Emancipation Day (Caribbean communities), Black & African Diaspora Celebrations, Juneteenth, Lunar New Year, Lantern Festival, Ramadan (programming across the month), Eid al-Fitr, Christmas, Easter, Pride Month (June), Transgender Day of Visibility, Neighborhood Anniversaries & Oral History Days, Community Block & Park Days



# SEASONAL

## PROGRAMMING CALENDAR

### WINTER

#### WINTER (JAN-MARCH)

##### Theme: Reflection, Heritage & Skill-Building

- Winter artist residencies
- Textile & craft intensives
- Oral history preservation project
- Black History observance
- Indoor performances & readings

### SPRING

#### SPRING (APRIL-JUNE)

##### Theme: Renewal, Youth & Public Art

- Youth exhibitions
- Public art & mural workshops
- Neighborhood history walks
- School partnerships & field trips
- Community gardening & sustainability workshops

### SUMMER

#### SUMMER (JULY-SEPTEMBER)

##### Theme: Celebration & Outdoor Activation

- Summer arts camps
- Outdoor performances (ROAR Fest)
- Cultural heritage festivals
- Teen creative fellowships
- Community markets & fairs

### FALL

#### FALL (OCTOBER-DECEMBER)

##### Theme: Legacy, Storytelling & Gathering

- Artist showcases
- Intergenerational storytelling series
- Día de los Muertos / cultural remembrance events
- Year-end exhibitions
- Community harvest celebrations

METRICS & IMPACT TRACKING LESCC will track:  
Attendance numbers + Percentage of free programs  
Youth participation + Demographic reach  
Local artist engagement + Community partner collaborations

This data will be shared with NYC Parks annually.

# CAPITAL HISTORY

## COMMUNITY EFFORTS FOR REVITALIZATION OF ALLEN STREET COMFORT STATION

In 2008, Hester Street, in partnership with AAFE, led a community-based design initiative for the Allen and Pike Street pedestrian malls. That process resulted in capital funding for renovations to several segments of the malls between Hester Street and Delancey Street, as well as between the East River waterfront and Henry Street. Those improvements were completed by NYC Parks between 2011–2012, alongside protected bike lanes and greenway infrastructure installed by NYC DOT. However, the scope and available resources did not extend to a full renovation of the remaining pedestrian malls or the abandoned comfort station building at Delancey Street. It's also worth noting that some of the completed work from that period has since experienced deterioration, including chipped pavement and damaged benches, indicating a renewed need for investment.



## COLLABRATIVE EFFORTS F OR ASSET RESTORATION

As part of the 2008 initiative, Hester Street published a study and recommendations report that explicitly identified the Delancey Street comfort station as a strong candidate for reuse as a community space. In subsequent years, Hester Street also led several temporary art installations in the pedestrian malls, most notably in 2010 in collaboration with NYC DOT, to activate the area before and during capital improvements.

In 2011, approximately \$1 million in funding was allocated by the Lower Manhattan Development Corporation for the renovation of the abandoned comfort station at Delancey. Hester Street advocated for this allocation; however, the funding appears to have been absorbed into Parks Department processes, and no renovation work ultimately occurred at the site.

Around the same time, there were also exploratory efforts by Times Up!, the bicycle advocacy organization, to convert the building into a cycling hub—an idea that predated many of the subsequent bike infrastructure improvements along the Delancey Street corridor.

For many years following, Manhattan Community Board 3 has consistently included both the remaining pedestrian mall renovations and the Delancey Street comfort station in its annual capital budget requests to the City, though to our knowledge, these requests have not yet resulted in implementation.







Taken together, this history demonstrates long-standing community support, prior capital recognition at the \$1M+ level, and repeated identification of the comfort station as a viable community-use asset.

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## MOVING FORWARD

Prior capital assessments by NYC Parks indicate that a renovation budget of approx \$2M is appropriate for bringing the structure to full use. Our proposed cultural program offers a more flexible, phased capital plan that can begin activation at a significantly lower initial cost while pursuing supplemental capital in partnership with public and private funders. Prior funding attempts, restoration specs and capital recognition at the \$1M+ level has set important precedent for framing a \$2M renovation estimate (for this stretch of mall at Allen and Delancey) as a reasonable and historically grounded starting point.

**An analysis of the building's footprint, anticipated program volume, and precedent investments in similarly scaled cultural facilities supports a \$350K discretionary City Council allocation as an efficient, high-return investment in public access & community benefit.**



# CAPITAL PLAN

## RENOVATION SCOPE & CAPITAL PLAN

Previous capital planning efforts for the building identified a renovation scope in the range of \$1.2 million, for the building alone, directly reflecting the level of investment required to bring the structure into full, code-compliant use. This prior assessment demonstrates both the physical viability of the building and the City's historical recognition of its value as a public asset. Building on this precedent, LESCC proposes a phased capital and funding strategy that allows for early activation of the site while pursuing comprehensive capital improvements in partnership with public and private funders.

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A phased renovation will upgrade the building into a safe, ADA-compliant, modern facility for the community.

### IMPROVEMENTS INCLUDE:

- Structural and roof repairs
- ADA ramp + accessible restrooms
- Updated HVAC and electrical systems
- Energy-efficient lighting
- Flexible studio and exhibition partitions
- Cosmetic interior + exterior upgrades
- All work will follow NYC sustainability and historic preservation guidelines.

Exterior improvements that respect the historic character of the building

All renovation work will be guided by sustainability standards and overseen by licensed architects and contractors with experience in NYC public projects.



# RENOVATION & CAPITAL IMPROVEMENTS



To bring the building up to modern standards, we anticipate a phased renovation.

## EXPECTED COSTS

- Structural and roof repairs
- New HVAC and energy-efficient systems
- ADA accessibility upgrades, including ramps and compliant restrooms
- Updated electrical and lighting suitable for creative use
- Multi-room buildout
- Installation of flexible, multi-use interior partitions
- Full code compliance for performance/events/occupancy loads >50
- Sprinklers/safety measures

## EXPECTED CHALLENGES

- **Change of use / occupancy type:** turning restrooms into a space used by the public (especially assembly) triggers much stricter code and fire-safety requirements.
- **Hazards & concealed conditions:** asbestos, lead paint, insect/deteriorated framing, or major roof/structural issues blow budgets quickly.
- **Accessibility:** ramps, widened doors, an accessible restroom or lift can be costly on a small footprint.
- **Mechanical systems:** original restroom houses often have no modern HVAC, insufficient electrical service, or aging plumbing. Adding HVAC and adequate electrical is expensive in tight spaces.
- **Site constraints:** narrow sidewalks, historic detail preservation, and Parks/land-use permitting add time and cost.

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Exterior improvements that respect the historic character of the building. All renovation work will be guided by sustainability standards and overseen by licensed architects and contractors with experience in NYC public projects.

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# FUNDING & ESTIMATES



As part of our long-term planning, we anticipate the need to pursue City Council discretionary capital funding in Fiscal Year 2027 to support phased renovation and activation of the site. Knowing the allotment is \$5M per year, we plan to ask for \$350K, with additional funding sought through a variety of outlets, all highlighted in these materials. We are developing a responsible capital strategy that allows for early public benefit while advancing toward full code-compliant improvements over time.

## HARD COSTS (CONSTRUCTION)

- Abatement (asbestos/lead if present) — \$5K–\$30K
- Structural / roof repairs — \$10K–\$80K
- Exterior repairs / new doors & windows — \$5K–\$40K
- Accessibility (ramp, handrails, accessible restroom conversion) — \$25K–\$150K
- HVAC (mini-split systems + ducting) — \$10K–\$60K
- Electrical upgrade (service, lighting, outlets) — \$15K–\$80K
- Plumbing (rework, new drains, hand sinks, backflow prevention) — \$8K–\$40K
- Fire safety & alarms (detectors, panel; sprinklers if required) — \$10K–\$120K
- Interior partitions, finishes, flooring, paint — \$8K–\$50K
- Sitework (fencing, signage, exterior lighting) — \$3K–\$25K

## SOFT COSTS (OTHER)

- Architect / engineer / code analysis / schematic design — \$8K–\$40K
- Permits, DOB filings, inspections — \$3K–\$25K
- Project management / construction contingency (20–30%) — variable: \$30K–\$150K
- Furniture, AV, basic equipment (portable seating, projector, shelving) — \$3K–\$25K
- Insurance, legal, community outreach materials — \$2K–\$12K

## BALLPARK ESTIMATES

- **Mid-level cultural activation** (permanent conversion to small gallery / micro-studio / workshop space; moderate upgrades, HVAC, electrical, ADA access): \$150,000 – \$550,000.
- **Full code-compliant reuse for public assembly / permanent cultural center** (major renovation: structural, full MEP, accessibility, fire protection, permits, months of work): \$500,000 – \$1.8M+.

# FUNDING PIPELINE

The Lower East Side Cultural Center (LESCC) will be supported through a diversified and sustainable funding model that combines public investment, private philanthropy, earned revenue, and community support. This approach ensures both near-term feasibility and long-term operational stability.

## FINANCIAL SUSTAINABILITY

The LESCC will be supported through:

- Philanthropic grants
- Government funding
- Program fees + space rentals
- Sponsorships
- Community fundraising events



| Source      | Example                                                | Notes                                            |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| FOUNDATIONS | Mellon, Ford, NY Community Trust, LMCC                 | Area offices of Cultural Affairs                 |
| GOVERNMENT  | DCLA, DYCD, NYSCA, City Council Discretionary (\$350K) | Grants/Mayoral support/Funding already available |
| DONORS      | Local philanthropists, LES patrons, Bronfmans          | Board Members or LES institutions                |
| REVENUE     | Rentals, advanced classes, memberships                 | Early gifts and registry                         |

Based on the building’s square footage, projected annual public utilization, and comparable City-funded cultural facility activations, \$350k IS a right-sized investment to safely renovate, activate, and steward this footprint as a year-round, high-impact community asset.

# ESTIMATED YEARLY OPERATING BUDGET

The LESCC budget is intentionally conservative, diversified, and scalable, demonstrating fiscal responsibility while allowing for program growth over time. The model prioritizes long-term sustainability, public access/ affordability and gradual expansion as funding stabilizes

## ASSUMPTIONS

- Facility size: ~4,000–6,000 sq ft (adjustable)
- NYC Parks lease/concession fee: nominal or percentage-based
- Year 1 includes partial programming ramp-up
- Staff size grows modestly over 5 years
- At least 40% of programs remain free

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## YEAR 1 OPERATING BUDGET (START-UP YEAR) EXPENSES

### Personnel

- Executive Director (FT): \$85,000
- Program Manager (PT): \$35,000
- Teaching Artists & Facilitators: \$40,000
- Operations / Facilities (PT): \$25,000
- Payroll taxes & benefits: \$18,000

Total Personnel: \$203,000

### Facility & Administrative

- Utilities: \$30,000
- Insurance: \$12,000
- Maintenance & cleaning: \$18,000
- Office & technology: \$10,000
- Accounting, legal & audit: \$15,000
- Marketing & outreach: \$10,000

Total Facility/Admin: \$95,000

### Program Expenses

- Art supplies & materials: \$20,000
- Exhibitions & performances: \$15,000
- Youth program costs: \$12,000
- Community events & festivals: \$10,000

Total Program Expenses: \$57,000

**TOTAL YEAR 1 EXPENSES: \$355,000**

## YEAR 1 REVENUE

- Foundation & government grants: \$180,000
- Individual donations: \$50,000
- Program fees (sliding scale): \$45,000
- Space rentals & memberships: \$60,000
- Fundraising events: \$60,000

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**TOTAL YEAR 1 REVENUE: \$395,000**



# 5 YEAR OPERATIONAL BUDGET YEAR/EXPENSES REVENUE

## 5-YEAR FINANCIAL PROJECTION SUMMARY

Surpluses are directed to reserves, capital replacement, and program expansion.

| YEAR | EXPENSES | REVENUE |
|------|----------|---------|
| 1    | 355,000  | 395,000 |
| 2    | 385,000  | 405,000 |
| 3    | 420,000  | 430,000 |
| 4    | 460,000  | 475,000 |
| 5    | 505,000  | 520,000 |

**REVENUE MIX (ONGOING)** This diversified mix reduces reliance on any single funding source.

- Grants (public + private): 45–50%
- Earned income (classes, rentals, memberships): 30–35%
- Individual giving & events: 15–20%

**CAPITAL & RENOVATION FUNDING (SEPARATE FROM OPERATIONS)** Estimated renovation range: \$850,000–\$1.5M, depending on building condition.

Capital improvements will be funded through:

- City capital allocations
- Private foundation grants
- Individual major gifts
- Corporate sponsorships

### FINANCIAL CONTROLS & OVERSIGHT

- Board Finance Committee oversight
- Annual independent audit or review
- Segregated operating and capital accounts
- Regular reporting to NYC Parks

### FINANCIAL SUSTAINABILITY STATEMENT

The Lower East Side Cultural Center is designed to operate responsibly within its means while steadily expanding public benefit. Diversified revenue streams ensure LESCC's long-term viability as a public-serving cultural institution.

# ABOUT THE APPLICANT



## MYLES SMUTNEY

Myles Smutney is a New York City-based cultural producer, curator, and founder of The Free Store Project, a community-led initiative focused on mutual aid, public programming, and equitable access to resources. She is a David Prize finalist, and District Leader candidate for the Lower East Side (2023).

She brings over a decade of experience working across the arts and nonprofit sectors, with a focus on activating shared spaces through inclusive, community-centered programming. As Director of the ROAR! Summer Festival in partnership with University Settlement, she produced over 200 hours of free public programming and coordinated more than 17 cultural events on the Lower East Side, working closely with artists, cultural organizations, and local stakeholders.

Through The Free Store Project, Myles has built and sustained partnerships with artists, donors, and community organizations, generating both financial and in-kind support through strategic outreach and relationship management. She has experience overseeing budgets, coordinating volunteers, and managing day-to-day operations of public-facing initiatives.

Her work is grounded in stewardship, accessibility, and long-term community engagement, with a commitment to maintaining safe, inclusive, and well-utilized public spaces.

The proposed Lower East Side Cultural Center builds on this experience, expanding his work into a permanent, community-serving facility aligned with NYC Parks' mission to activate underutilized public assets and increase equitable access to cultural resources.



# THANK YOU

## **RE: RFP & ADAPTATION OF PARKS DEPT BUILDING**

Thank you for taking the time to review these preliminary materials. We appreciate the opportunity to share an early vision for the Lower East Side Cultural Center and welcome any feedback on this early concept that may help.

The Lower East Side Cultural Center is intended as a community-centered, public-serving use for this site, and we look forward to the possibility of continuing this conversation as things progress.

We value any guidance that can help refine the proposal ahead of the formal RFP process.

We appreciate your time and consideration.

With sincere appreciation,

Myles Smutney  
Founder  
The Free Store Project  
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EIN: 86-3917845  
Non-profit organization.